LAF YOMI

Bekhorot 55 · November 12, 2026

ON TODAY'S DAF

Bekhorot 55 asks when scattered animals count as one flock for the animal tithe: five sheep here and five there combine only if something in the middle joins them — one sheep, the shepherd, his implements, or perhaps his dog, which Rav Ashi leaves unresolved. Then the Jordan: does it divide flocks because it is a Torah border in its own right, or because it cannot be crossed? The daf traces the Jordan from Dan and the Cave of Pamyas, and the Euphrates as the source of all waters, closing with Shmuel's father and his daughters' mikveh in the river.

RAV ASHI'S DOG · THE MIDDLE THAT MAY OR MAY NOT JOIN



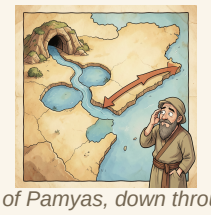
1. Rav Ashi asks: what if the shepherd's dog is in the middle? Does the dog combine the two flocks into one, or not?

“Since the shepherd can call the dog and it comes, maybe the dog doesn't combine — the shepherd never needs to go there himself. But sometimes, just because the shepherd calls the dog, the dog doesn't come, and then the shepherd has to go and fetch it himself. The Gemara leaves it a teiku — and every dog owner in the shiur understood exactly why.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 55a · כלבו של רועה — the shepherd's dog in the middle · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 9:45

THE JORDAN'S COURSE · EAST RIVER, WEST SEA



2. The baraita traces the Jordan from the Cave of Pamyas, down through the Hula, the Kinneret and the Dead Sea — and then, it says, it goes on and falls into the Great Sea.

“Rav Chaim Kanievsky in Derech Emunah points out the problem: the Jordan runs down the east side of the Land, and the Mediterranean is on the west side. So how does the Jordan pour into the Great Sea?”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 55a · ירדן יוצא ממערת פמיאס — and falls into the Great Sea? · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 21:43

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WHY JORDAN? · GOD'S SELF-RESTRAINT



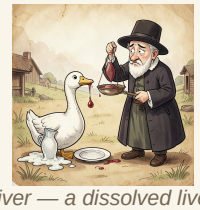
3. The midrash asks: the miracles at the Sea were far greater than at the Jordan — so why does the verse call the Jordan's splitting God's gevurot, His mighty acts?

“Jeroboam set up a golden calf in Dan, where the Jordan begins — and God split the river anyway. He knew what would come, and He did it regardless. That is gevurah: conquering His own inclination, just as Pirkei Avot says — who is mighty? One who conquers his inclination.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 55a · למה נקרא שמו ירדן — it descends from Dan · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 22:58

THE LIVER · FLESH, BLOOD, OR BOTH?



4. Rav Kahana says the source of blood is the liver — a dissolved liver imparts impurity like a quarter-log of blood. But then, how may we eat liver at all?

“The Maharam Schick was asked about goose liver that got mixed with milk: is that meat-and-milk, which is forbidden even for benefit — or blood-and-milk, which is not? The liver sits exactly on the line between flesh and blood.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 55a · שחורתא דדמא כבדא — the source of blood is the liver · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 29:10

SHMUEL'S FATHER · MIKVEH LOGISTICS



5. Shmuel's father made mikvaot for his daughters in Nisan, when the river might be mostly rainwater — but in Tishrei he let them immerse in the Euphrates itself, with mats laid down in the river.

“Why the mats? One view: the riverbed is muddy, and mud would be a chatzitzah. The other: the mats were a partition around the spot, so the girls wouldn't feel rushed immersing undressed in a public place — and could do it properly. Even a river mikveh gets a mechitza.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 55b · מפני ביומי דתשרי — mats in Tishrei · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 36:55